University of Glasgow

# Taking Words to Pieces

**Marc Alexander**

English Language & Linguistics 2A, Week 3

# What Is a Morpheme?

unhelpfulness

un help ful ness


un
help
ful
ness


help
ful
ness


help
ful

help


help
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un
help
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un
help
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help
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lust
ful
grey
ness


un
help
ful
ness

un help ful ness

unhelpfulness

unhelpfulness

cars

readable

preview

unhelpfulness

cars

readable

preview

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

**‘Base’ or ‘Root’**

Carries main meaning, often a morpheme that can stand on its own

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

**‘Affix’**

Can’t stand on its own, carries additional meaning

# Three Types of Words



**Simple**



**Complex**



**Compound**

# Simple

- A base/root on its own
  - *car*
  - *green*
  - *avocado*
  - *on*

# Complex

- A base/root with one or more bound morphemes (like affixes)
  - *driver*
  - *bilingual*
  - *subway*
  - *likely*
  - *education*

# 🔗 Compound

- Multiple bases/roots
  - *overcook*
  - *stirfry*
  - *dryclean*
  - *sky-high*
  - *signwriter*

# Three Types of Words



**Simple**



**Complex**



**Compound**

# Warnings!

- Do not confuse word length with number of morphemes!
  - *catamaran*
  - *knickerbocker*
  - *tenths* (*ten -th -s*)
- Do not confuse number of syllables with number of morphemes!
  - *car/cars*
  - *cardigan, avocado*

# Types of Morphemes

# Free and Bound

## Free

**Free** to be used as independent words on their own, can be the base/root of a compound or complex word

(Most bases are free – but not all!)

## Bound

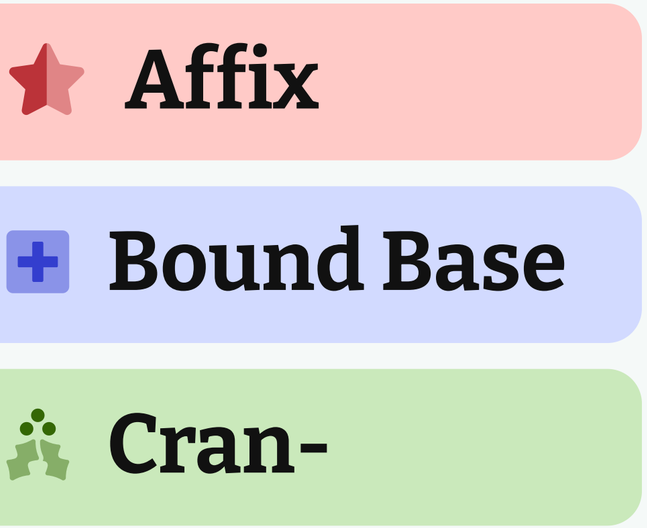
Cannot exist on their own and must be **bound** to another morpheme to make a word

(All affixes are bound, but there are other types of bound morphemes!)

# Free or Bound?

| Word | FREE | BOUND |
|---|---|---|
| *car* | *car* | |
| *view* | *view* | |
| *preview* | *view* | *pre-* |
| *seasonal* | *season* | *-al* |
| *unhelpfulness* | *help* | *un-, -ful, -ness* |

# Bound Morphemes



# Affix

- Must be added to a base
- Can be prefix, suffix, or (rarely) infix
  - *love, lovely*
  - *sense, nonsense*
  - *capable, incapable, incapability*
  - *absolutely, absofuckinglutely*

# Affix: Plurals

How much do people notice a borrowed plural?

**Nobody notices**

*oxen*
*agenda*
*formulae*

→

**Nobody minds**

*supernovae*
*supernovas*

→

**Some people wince**

*millennia*
*millenniums*
*platypuses*

→

**Everyone notices**

*dogmata*

*formulas or formulae? forums or fora?*

# Bound Base

- A base which cannot stand on its own but requires some affix
- Carries lexical meaning
  - *dexterity*, **dexter*
  - *reject*, **ject*
  - *produce, deduce, reduce, induce*, **duce*

# Bound Base

Look at these two sets of words, some of which have similar meanings but **a** has free bases and **b** has bound bases. Is there anything you notice about **a** and **b** compared to each other?

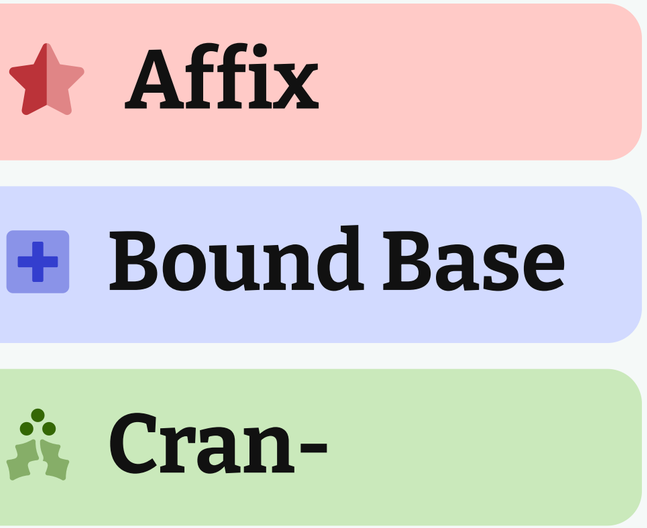
**a**: *readable hearing enlarge performance whiteness darken seeker*

**b**: *legible audience magnify rendition clarity obfuscate applicant*

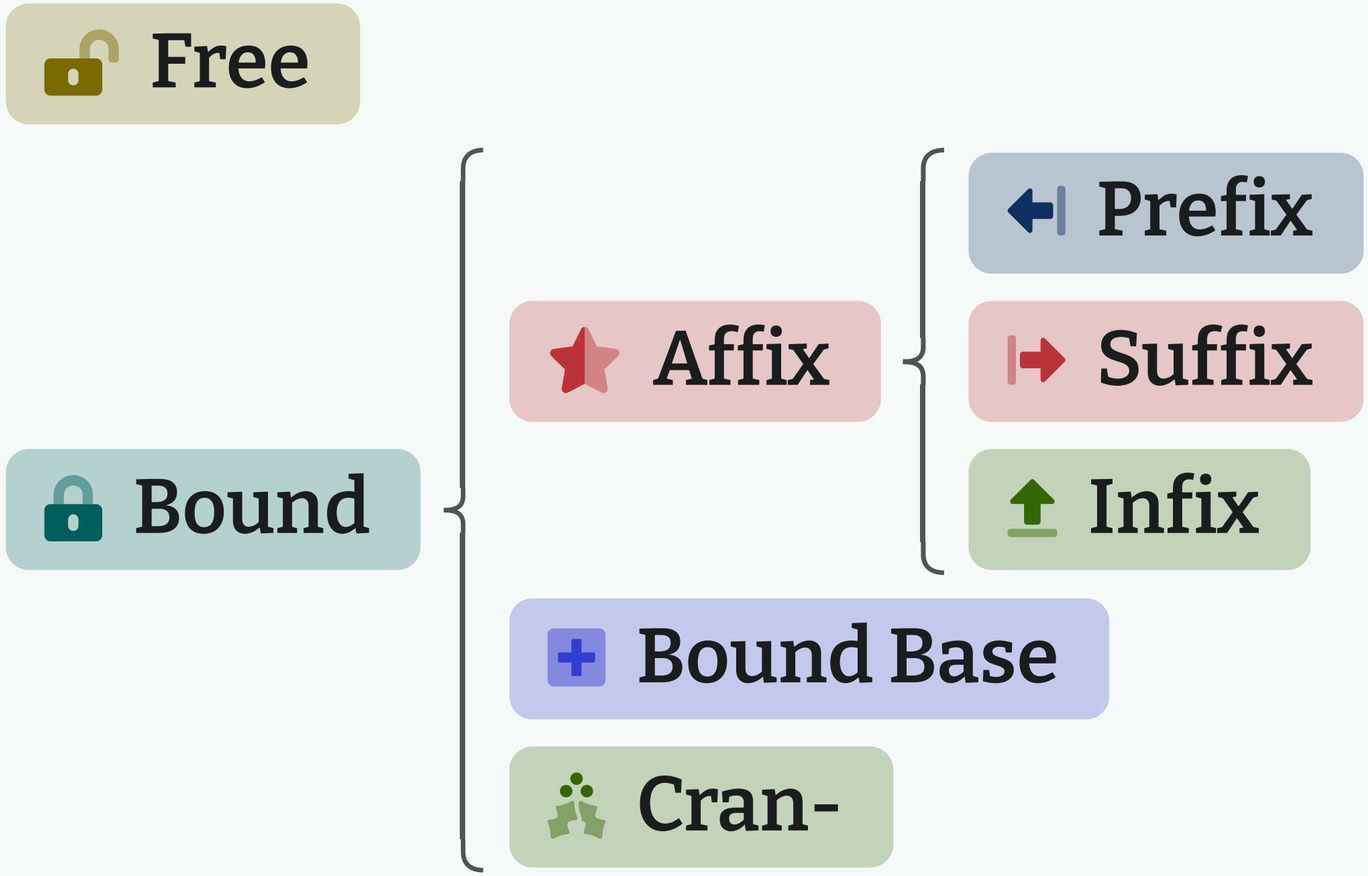
# Cran-

- Bound morphemes which are entirely unproductive and are limited to one word
  - *cranberry*
  - *huckleberry*
  - *gormless*
  - *cobweb*
  - *lukewarm*

# Bound Morphemes



# Free and Bound Morphemes



# Libfixes

## A liberated affix

- a piece of an existing word breaks free and becomes a productive affix, usually a suffix
- *spectacular* → *-tacular*  *alcoholic* → *-holic*

## The term

- Arnold Zwicky, 2010: *liberated* + *affix*
- *libfix* is now itself in the Cambridge Dictionary

# Libfixes

coined before 2015

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *Euro-* | Europe | *Europhile, Eurosceptic, Eurocentric* |
| *-tacular* | spectacular | *spooktacular, craptacular* |
| *-tastic* | fantastic | *funtastic, craptastic* |
| *-holic* | alcoholic | *chocoholic, pastaholic, yogaholic* |
| *-dar* | radar | *gaydar, geekdar, sarcasmdar, dogdar* |
| *-gate* | Watergate | *Partygate, Signalgate* |
| *-gasm* | orgasm | *braingasm, eargasm, eyegasm, foodgasm* |
| *-licious* | delicious | *soda-licious, bootylicious* |
| *-mageddon* | Armageddon | *snowmageddon, carmageddon, toemageddon* |
| *-verse* | universe | *multiverse, blogoverse, Twitterverse* |

## Libfixes

more recent

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *-core* | hardcore | *normcore, cottagecore, Barbiecore* |
| *-pilled* | red pill | *fish-oil-pilled, Letterboxd-pilled* |
| *-maxxing* | looksmaxxing | *proteinmaxxing, tokenmaxxing* |
| *-ussy* | | ADS Word of the Year 2022 |
| *-dle* | | ADS Digital Word of the Year 2022 |

# Libfixes

## *-licious*

Older than you think

> ‘Oh! but this is soda-licious!’

*New York Observer and Chronicle*, 3 January 1878

By 1911, drug stores in Ada, Oklahoma and Fort Wayne, Indiana advertise *soda-licious* drinks

A Victorian libfix, not an internet one

## *-dar*

A fragment of a fragment

*radar* = RAdio Detecting And Ranging, so *-dar* is a piece of an acronym

*gaydar* popularised it; then *geekdar, sarcasmdar, dogdar*

*… and nundar*

## *-gate*

Fifty years of scandal

*Watergate* (1972): an office building in Washington DC

*Partygate* (2021)

*Signalgate* (2025)

English had no short productive way to name a scandal

# Libfixes

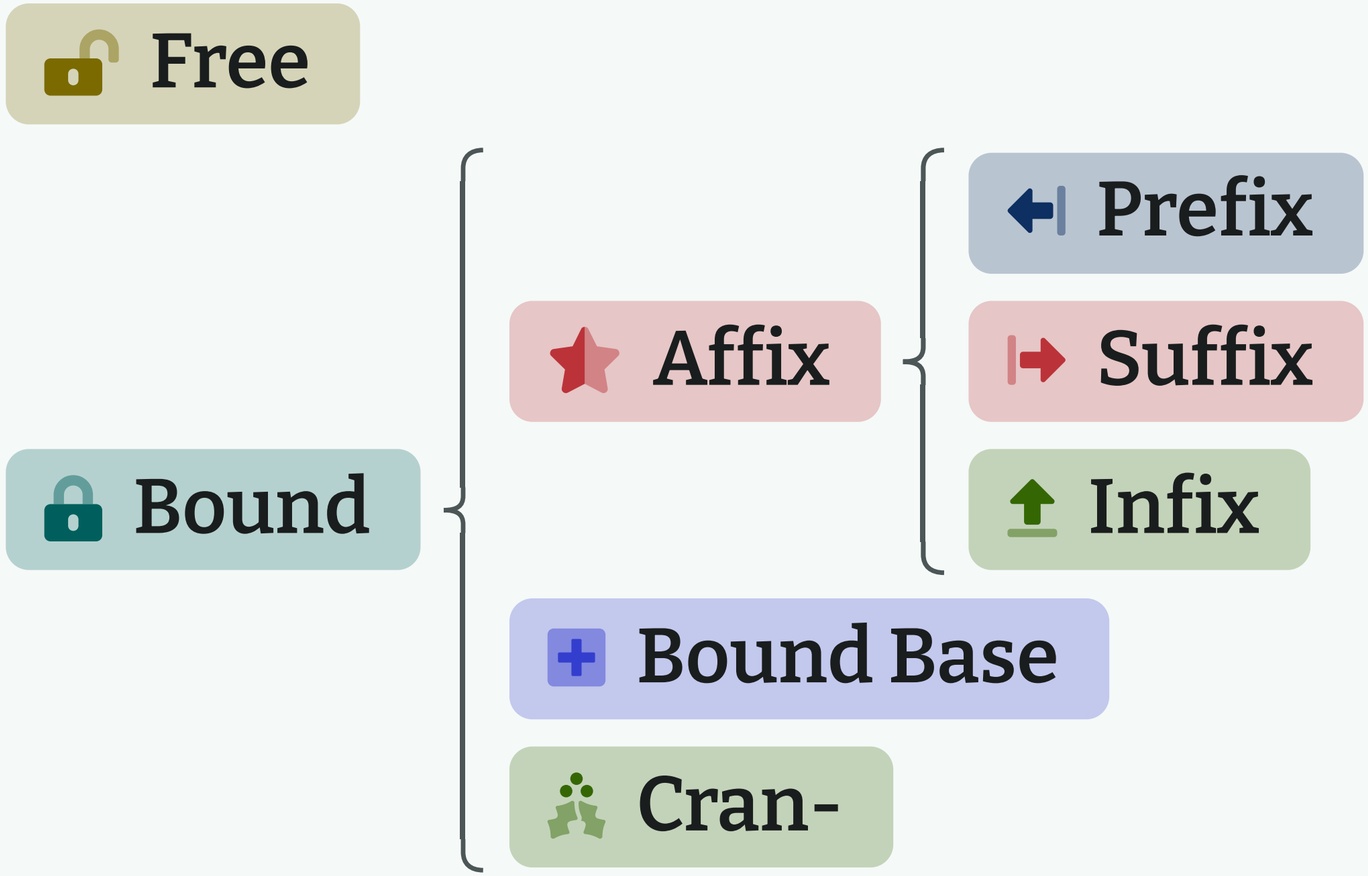
Productivity is temporary

| Hot | → | Stable | → | Cooling | → | Historic, alive | → | Used and died |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *-core*<br>*-pilled*<br>*-maxxing*<br>*-ussy* | | *-gate*<br>*-gasm*<br>*-holic* | | *-mageddon*<br>*-verse*<br>*-tacular* | | *-licious* | | *quaran-* |

*quaran-* ADS Most Creative, 2020: *quarantini, quaranteam, quaranbeard*. Gone within 18 months.

Which of the ‘hot’ will still be productive in 2036…?

# Free and Bound Morphemes



# How Are Morphemes Used?

# So Why...?

- Why do we use morphemes?
  - Economy!
- How do we use English morphemes?
  - Lexeme formation
  - Inflection

# Changes

| | |
|---|---|
| **happy + *un-* → unhappy** | MEANING CHANGE Aj → Aj ‘negative of Aj’ |
| **amuse + *-ment* → amusement** | CATEGORY CHANGE V → N |
| **wash + *-able* → washable** | MEANING AND CATEGORY CHANGE V → Aj ‘able to be Ved’ |

# Some Changes

## Some meaning changes

Aj → Aj ‘negative Aj’
*happy → unhappy*

N → N ‘place where N lives’
*orphan → orphanage*

V → V ‘repeat V’
*wash → rewash*

## Some category changes

V → N
*amuse → amusement*

V → Aj
*impress → impressive*

N → Aj
*monster → monstrous*

# A Puzzle

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| *respect* | → | *disrespect* | |
| *satisfied* | → | *dissatisfied* | |
| *ease* | → | *disease* | |
| *proper* | → | *improper* | not **disproper* |
| *pertinent* | → | *impertinent* | not **dispertinent* |

# Restrictions on Affixes



**Etymological**

*-en* will attach to native bases but not Latinate bases, *-ic* will only attach to French/Latin bases



**Categorical**

*-ity* can only be added to Aj, *-ize* to N or Aj, *un-* to Aj or V



**Phonological**

*-ize* prefers N and Aj bases of two or more syllables with no primary stress on the final syllable, while *-en* (Aj → V) attaches only to bases ending in plosives, fricatives, and affricates



**Syntactic**

*-able* attaches to transitive verbs



**Semantic**

*un-* can only be added to bases not already negative in meaning

# Inflection

- As well as lexeme formation, morphemes help *inflect* English
  - Signal grammatical relationships
- Comparatively rare in English
  - Nouns (3 types)
  - Verbs (5 types)
  - Adjectives/Adverbs (3 types)
  - Remember, inflection isn't *just* morphology (eg *she/her*)

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